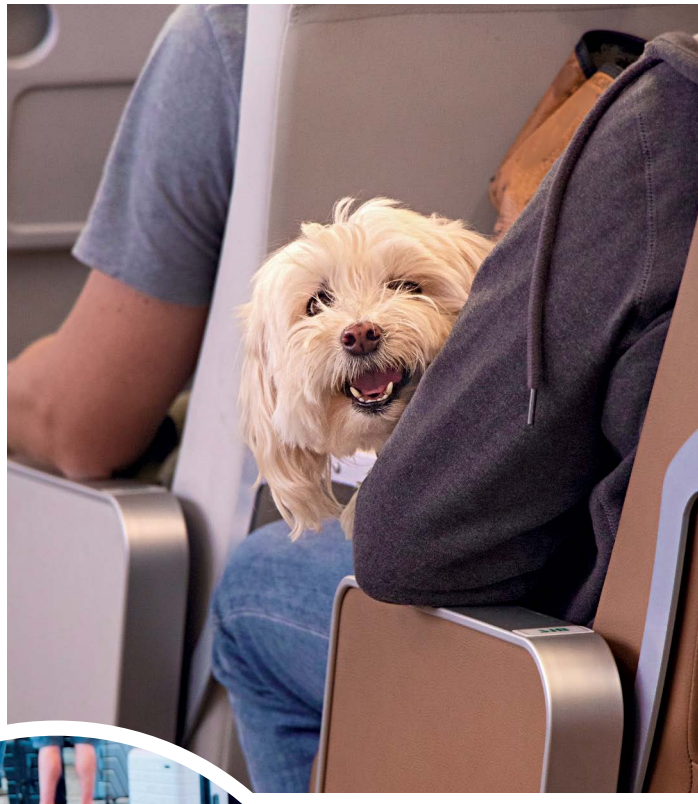


EARLIER THIS YEAR, when Romeo boarded his 26th flight between Mumbai and Goa, he was a bit of an unusual frequent flyer. The miniature poodle was travelling on Akasa Air with his owner for a weekend getaway.

Romeo is part of a small but rapidly growing population of Indian pets taking to the skies. Akasa Air says it has flown more than 10,000 pets since launching Pets on Akasa in November 2022; 93% travelled in the cabin, and more than a quarter of pet parents used the service more than once. The festive quarter from October to December accounts for almost 35% of its annual pet journeys. Air India, meanwhile, carried around 1,700 pets in the first six months of 2026. What was once an eccentric request at an airline counter is fast becoming a recognisable Indian travel category.



Among major airlines, Air India and Akasa Air are the two practical options for passengers who want a structured service for travelling with their pets

"Pets are no longer necessarily left behind with a neighbour or at a boarding kennel. They are increasingly coming along for the holiday and, of course, the relocation," says New Delhi-based Sanjana Kapoor, who flies frequently with her Shih Tzu, Coco. Of course, she says, it's because her pet is small enough to fit in the cabin that she prefers to take him along rather than leave him in a boarding. "If my dog was larger, maybe I wouldn't want to put him in the hold of an aircraft on vacation; in that case, I would have left him at a kennel," she adds.

Among major airlines, Air India and Akasa Air are the two practical options for passengers who want a structured service for travelling with their pets. But here, too, it's only dogs and cats. You cannot fly with your pet rabbits, for instance. IndiGo does not permit regular pets on its aircraft and makes an exception for guide dogs accompanying blind passengers.

Air India's revamped Paws on Board programme allows domesticated cats and dogs weighing up to 10 kg, including the carrier, in Economy class. The pet must stay inside a soft-sided, leak-proof, ventilated carrier no larger than 17x10x9 inches, placed beneath the seat. Cabin pets must be at least eight weeks old, and bookings should be made at least 48 hours before departure. Pets are seated with their humans in aisle seats in the last five rows. Pregnant, sedated, critically